his argument. However, he felt there seemed to be more to the assassination than just the LTTE.

The limelight had by now again fallen on *India Today*'s coverage of the assassination case. Anirudhya was expected to entertain his 'sources, contacts and friends in high places' with the latest updates on the progress of the investigation. Lunch, high tea and dinner invitations were on the rise. He was getting caught between office and the world outside. Shekhar Gupta made it easy for him. 'Anirudhya, remember your only allegiance is to your stories, your readers and your editor. Rest everything can wait.'

Gupta was teaching him how to say no to invitations.

'But Shekhar,' Anirudhya spoke hesitatingly. 'How do I ignore my sources?'

'They can wait. They give you stories in their own interest. As long as you are in a position of power, at least in their perspective, they won't turn their back on you.'

'I hope so.'

'Relax. Go home after office. You look washed up.'

'Thanks, Shekhar.'

The assassination plot continued to thicken even as the number of potential targets multiplied. Fresh intelligence reports from the IB suggested that the LTTE had bigger plans in place, with a long hit list. The assassination squad wanted to eliminate at least three more VIPs—Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Jayalalithaa, the state Congress President V.K. Ramamurthy and the director general of Tamil Nadu Police, S. Sripal. The Q branch had picked up some suspects in that connection and handed them over to the SIT for further investigation.

The conspiracy appeared to have had international links. Interrogation of suspects and documents seized indicated that Sivarasan, the man who wove the complex web of the assassination and its aftermath, was in regular contact with people in London, Sweden, Singapore, France, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. All these countries had been bases to key members of the LTTE. Kittu, the head of the international wing of the LTTE, was in London. Anton Balasingham, Prabhakaran's political adviser, was in